

Chapter 131-7

Xu Qingzhu was surprised: "You didn't go eat lunch?"

"I've been thinking about it for two days." Zhou Yi'an said very solemnly. "I still had to come ask you."

"What?" Xu Qingzhu sat in her chair, her hand resting casually on the desk.

"When did Liang Shi change?" Zhou Yi'an asked. "Or rather, how long did she remain as she was before?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"What answer do you want?" Xu Qingzhu asked her in return.

Zhou Yi'an pressed her lips together, then threw the question back at her: "What answer are you willing to tell me?"

"What that woman said that day—it should have been Liang Shi passing a message to you." Zhou Yi'an rotated the decorative ring on her finger. "So where is she now? And where is... the person from before?"

From the night Zhou Yi'an had called her, Xu Qingzhu knew this conversation was coming.

Zhou Yi'an was very smart. She could easily deduce a clue from Sun Chengcheng's words.

And then confront Xu Qingzhu with conclusions that were half-guessed and half-reasoned.

Xu Qingzhu paused for two seconds and could only answer honestly: "I don't know."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

"We suspected before that Liang Shi had a split personality." Xu Qingzhu said. "But later we realized that probably wasn't it. If you really want to know the answer, perhaps only Liang Shi can answer that question for you."

Zhou Yi'an lowered her eyes, the motion of rotating her ring becoming faster.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, and when their eyes inadvertently met, she suddenly asked: "So you liked the original Liang Shi?"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

As if unwilling to admit that she and Xu Qingzhu liked the same person—that Xu Qingzhu had won while she had not—her answering voice was very soft, almost a very low hum: "Mm."

"Why did you like her?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhou Yi'an: ".....There isn't always a 'why' for everything."

Zhou Yi'an's tone was sharp, but she had already restrained herself somewhat.

This was already her restrained self when angry. She furrowed her brows: "So where has the current Liang Shi gone?"

"I don't know." Xu Qingzhu answered again.

Somewhat powerlessly.

Zhou Yi'an raised her eyes to look at her. "Then what do you know?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Do you have to speak so sharply?"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

The office fell quiet.

After a moment, Zhou Yi'an said: "You'll never know what it's like to find someone like yourself..."

"Sis sis sis!" Su Meiqi's voice came from outside. She knocked once on the door and pushed it open, directly interrupting Zhou Yi'an's words. As soon as she entered, she rushed straight to the desk like a gust of wind, staring at Xu Qingzhu with a serious expression: "I might know why Sister Liang hasn't woken up from her coma."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hmm?"

Su Meiqi widened her eyes and held up one finger: "She very likely traveled back to her own world!"

"Do you know the concept of parallel universes?" Su Meiqi said. "That's what it is. Otherwise, I really can't figure out why she would be in a coma for so long when advanced medicine can't explain it."

Su Meiqi said seriously with furrowed brows: "If one day she really can't wake up, it's very possible that all our memories will be erased. Or she'll just die, or she might wake up with a different personality—all of these are possible!"

She rubbed her chin. "What do you think—if I wait for a ten-planet alignment¹ to try transmigrating, would my chances be good?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Just as she was daydreaming, someone flicked the back of her head.

The force wasn't light either.

Su Meiqi covered her head and looked back, finding Zhou Yi'an staring at her eerily.

Su Meiqi: "....."

She said plaintively: "Sister An, when did you get here? You walk without making any sound. Also, stop hitting me—you've already knocked me stupid."

"You still know that you need a ten-planet alignment to transmigrate." Zhou Yi'an scoffed lightly. "You don't seem that stupid."

Su Meiqi: "....."

Speaking of this, Su Meiqi became energized. Her eyes sparkled: "Or a nine-planet alignment would work too. Failing that, there are also legendary treasures, newly opened wormholes—generally, any unusual celestial phenomenon is a good opportunity to transmigrate."

"How did you study physics and politics in school?" Zhou Yi'an raised an eyebrow. "Did you buy your way into that prestigious university? Why do you believe in such things?"

Su Meiqi instantly lost her composure and loudly argued back: "Existence is reasonable!² You can't say something doesn't! Exist! Just because you haven't seen it yourself!"

"Do you know that using a sick person for your fantasies is very impolite?" Zhou Yi'an said coldly.

Su Meiqi: "....."

"Bold hypotheses, careful verification?"³ Su Meiqi said this with less conviction. She looked at Zhou Yi'an, then at Xu Qingzhu, and finally pouted: "Sorry, sis. I was just saying."

Zhou Yi'an grabbed the back of her neck. "Skipping work to play around with your 2D stuff here⁴—do you want your dad to find out?"

At the mention of her dad, Su Meiqi jumped up like a mouse whose tail had been stepped on, immediately protesting: "Zhou Yi'an! You're going too far! You're a grown adult and you're still tattling to parents—you're being completely unreasonable!"

Zhou Yi'an pinched the back of her neck and threatened coldly: "What did you say?"

Su Meiqi: "....."

The two of them left Xu Qingzhu's office.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu sat in her office contemplating the possibilities of what Su Meiqi had said.

During her precious work time, she spent an hour researching those theories.

In the end, she discovered—she really had fallen for Su Meiqi's nonsense.

Setting aside the fact that unusual celestial phenomena were rare occurrences that might not happen once in ten years, just the stuff online about special constitutions and the like was obviously meant to fool children.

It was probably just a case of desperately seeking any solution.⁵

Xu Qingzhu suddenly laughed at the answers displayed on her computer.

Then she saw a message Zhou Yi'an had sent an hour ago: 【Don't discuss transmigration with chuunibyou⁶ girls.】

Xu Qingzhu stared at the screen and smiled.

Who would have thought that someone as contrary as Zhou Yi'an would also have considerate moments.

She replied with an "mm" and said nothing more.

Footnotes:

¹ **Ten-planet alignment (十星連珠)**: A rare astronomical event where multiple planets align in a row. In fiction and popular culture, such celestial events are often portrayed as triggers for supernatural occurrences like time travel or transmigration.

² **"Existence is reasonable" (存在即合理)**: A philosophical statement often attributed to Hegel, meaning "What is rational is actual and what is actual is rational." It's commonly used (sometimes incorrectly) to argue that anything that exists must have a reason for existing.

³ **"Bold hypotheses, careful verification" (大膽猜測，小心求證)**: A famous quote from Chinese scholar Hu Shih about the scientific method—make daring hypotheses but verify them carefully with evidence.

⁴ **2D stuff (二次元)**: Refers to the world of anime, manga, and related fiction. "2D" (two-dimensional) contrasts with "3D" (three-dimensional/real life). Here, Zhou Yi'an is dismissing Su Meiqi's transmigration theories as anime-inspired fantasies.

⁵ **Desperately seeking any solution (病急亂投醫)**: A Chinese idiom literally meaning "when seriously ill, one will try any doctor." It describes someone in desperate circumstances who will try anything, even unreasonable solutions.

⁶ **Chuunibyou (中二)**: A Japanese term (adopted into Chinese internet slang) referring to the "eighth-grader syndrome"—adolescent delusions of grandeur where teenagers believe they have special powers or knowledge. Here it's used to describe Su Meiqi's fantastical theories about transmigration.